

Casting Capital: How Credit Scores Re-Face Exchange

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Abstract

In this (in progress) paper, I visit a unique technological site: the emergence in the late twentieth century of credit and FICO scores. This new form of capital has been interrogated as a locus of institutional power by scholars like Poon (2012), Fourcade and Healy (2013, 2017), Lauer (2017), and Carruthers (2022). In particular, authors argue that the widespread institutional adoption of these scores as instruments to evaluate prospective debtors (individuals seeking loans or lines of credit from the bank), rather than fairly grading how likely individual consumers are to pay back loans, has produced and reproduced totalizing financial behaviors and created a mandatory, impersonal, institutionally imposed “financial identity” for all but the most financially privileged socioeconomic strata (Lauer 2017). I extend this literature by investigating how another role in the credit-seeking encounter has changed: that of the representative of the bank. By conducting a content analysis of the *FDIC Consumer News* and the consumer advice literature before and after the adoption of FICO scores, I examine not only how the idealized role of the financial self evolved from a trustworthy navigator of social encounters into a true-believing supplicant at an algorithmic altar, but also how the idealized bank representative coevolved with it from a canny and personable financial professional into a haruspical interpreter of the algorithmic will. I treat these consumer advice texts as Goffmanian scripts for action and theorize that by studying both sides of algorithmically transforming interactions like this, sociologists can observe the inner workings of institutions as they cross Illich (1973)’s “second watershed,” the point at which an institution begins inventing more problems than it solves.

Introduction

The social capital that influences, explicitly or implicitly, every market exchange in capitalist society is accumulated and displayed via the cultivation of *face*. Goffman (1955) describes face as “an image of self delineated in terms of approved social attributes.” A person accrues “positive social value” — an idea sociologists since Bourdieu might recognize better under the alias of “social capital” — when others interpret the “line” they have taken in some interaction to have been in harmony with their socially assigned role. According to Goffman, the maintenance of face is essential for successful interactions; when a person fails to live up to the role their face suggests they ought to, they “lose face” (and consequently social capital, we might add today). A key insight is that face is asymmetrical: a buyer may find their persona effective when negotiating with a friend or a seller who finds them charming, but be caught flat-footed when negotiating with a stranger or a seller their performance alienates. Similarly, Anthony may be more impressed by Barbara than Barbara is by Anthony; social capital does not necessarily run both ways. Buyers and sellers may also code switch, or try to change faces, in different

exchanges to maximize their results. In small but significant ways, these face imbalances compound to mean that what one puts into a market is not necessarily worth what one gets out.

Bourdieu (1986) writes that social capital is a credential which entitles its holder to credit, “in the various senses of the word.” By far the most relevant sense of “credit” in contemporary economic sociology is “other people’s money;” that is, someone wants to perform an exchange but lacks the liquid financial capital to do so, so they find a creditor to spot them the funds. In the burgeoning United States during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, credit became a ubiquitous means of purchasing goods and services, competing with hard cash at the point of sale (and sometimes superseding it) long before anyone started talking about a “cashless society” (Carruthers 2022). Despite not being involved much in personal finance for most of economic history, it was during this period that banks became the predominant lenders of credit for everyday Americans, especially for large purchases like a house or a car but increasingly for everyday transactions by means of institutionally provided tools like credit cards.

Until the late twentieth century, prospective debtors seeking credit from banks believed that the encounter with the representative of the bank was a situational performance of trust mediated by face. By playing the part of a “creditworthy” citizen in a face-to-face encounter, the prospective debtor could impress the bank rep and convince them that they were likely to make good on the loan. However, this state of affairs naturally entailed risk of non-repayment if the performance was more reliable than the debtor behind it. Banks attempted to mitigate this risk by standardizing how their representatives evaluated prospective borrowers, first by replacing holistic assessments of character with short written reports and eventually, with the help of national financial institutions, replacing them entirely with credit scores (Lauer 2017, Carruthers 2022). The most relevant credit score for the purposes of this paper is the FICO score, a metric derived from “scorecards” developed by the analytics firm Fair Isaac & Company Incorporated in the late 1950s that serves as the standard for assessing risk of non-repayment among financial professionals, landlords, credit unions, and especially banks (Poon 2012).

In 1989, the first FICO scoring algorithm was developed. In 1991, it was standardized across all major credit bureaus, and in 1995 its use in mortgage underwriting became mandatory. Since then, FICO scores have become an axiomatic feature of financial life in the United States. They determine what loans someone can take, what housing or vehicles they can buy, rent, or lease, whether they can act as guarantors for others in similar situations, and so on. Many scholars in economic sociology and science and technology studies contend that, rather than fairly evaluating individuals’ likelihood to make good on their debts, FICO scores produce and reproduce totalizing financial behaviors and create a mandatory, impersonal, institutionally imposed “financial identity” for all but the most financially privileged socioeconomic strata (Poon 2012, Fourcade and Healy 2013 & 2017, Lauer 2017). To extend Goffman’s metaphor, credit algorithms serve as “casting directors” for financial behavior. This “casting” does exactly what it sounds like: it replaces situational performances of trust with calcified, “objective” evaluations, reducing the range of tactics (Certeau 1980), social actions taken in everyday life to navigate the financial world, participants can reasonably apply to succeed in the market to those

the institutions determine they “ought” to do given their score. In some cases, FICO and related scoring algorithms reward characteristics and behavior that were always favored by prospective creditors (for example, having a large balance and steadily repaying small loans over time), but in others they incentivize behaviors that seem strange and counterintuitive (for example, leaving some loans outstanding instead of promptly repaying them and using credit cards for every purchase instead of cash or debit).

Scholars have mostly focused on the shifting role of the prospective debtor has changed as they try to navigate the “classification situations” in which they are essentially forced to participate as members of a society whose exchange networks are subject to algorithmic infrastructure like FICO scores (Fourcade and Healy 2013 & 2017). They remain responsible for some kind of face-work (Goffman 1955), but their audience is now the scoring algorithm that stratifies their life chances rather than the person across the table at the bank or at a social call. The idealized seeker of credit has been transfigured from a trustworthy and financially stable model citizen into a true-believing supplicant at an algorithmic altar (Lauer 2017), from an advocate of themselves into an advocate of “The 3-Digit Number That Shapes Your Financial Future” (Weston 2009). But much less ink has been spilled over how the other role in the credit-seeking encounter has changed, that of the representative of the bank. Their role has changed even more profoundly than that of their interlocutor, from a canny and personable financial professional with discretion to extend or withhold credit into a sort of *haruspex*, interpreting the outputs of the algorithms like a Roman priest would the entrails of a sacrifice. Their performance relies less on whether they give credit to those who can make good on it and more on whether the omens portended by the algorithms come to pass. Should the prospective debtor’s number qualify, the prospective creditor becomes a salesperson, should it be too low, an advisor. The introduction of credit scores has fundamentally changed the idealized bank rep from someone who *will or won’t* grant credit into someone who *can or can’t* grant credit. They are no longer really a representative of the bank; the algorithms that produce credit and FICO scores are the representatives of the bank. In many cases, human representatives are no longer even necessary for prospective debtors to secure a loan at all. This raises the question: how has the credit-seeking *interaction* changed along with the *institution*?

In this paper, I will investigate the credit-seeking encounter by using in-depth content analysis and iterative coding to interpret consumer advice literature in the popular press as well as from the FDIC as Goffmanian scripts for action. The characters in these scripts include prospective debtors, whose transformation from self-advocates into number-advocates is well-understood by the literature, but they also include bank representatives, loan officers, and so on, whose transformation from institutional representatives into accessories to financial algorithms has been less covered. My analysis is still in its early stages, so my findings here are preliminary, but they indicate that the once-prominent role of the bank rep as the primary gatekeeper to credit has been subsumed into the role of the credit scoring algorithm. The bank rep now takes a tertiary role in the encounter as an intermediary, interpreter, or even absent from the interaction entirely. I propose that analyzing interactional transformations along with

institutional transformations can help illuminate the inner workings of institutions as they cross Illich (1973)'s "second watershed," the point at which an institution begins inventing more problems than it solves.

Background

In *Tools for Conviviality* (1973), Ivan Illich describes two institutional "watersheds." The first occurs when an institution becomes rational in the sense that its marginal benefits exceed its marginal costs and harms. Illich uses the example of the institution of scientific medicine, which (according to him) was no more helpful in preventing or curing disease than home remedies or local healers until industrialization brought with it innovations like vaccines and penicillin. The second watershed occurs when an institution becomes rationalized in the sense that, to sustain itself, it begins introducing new problems it must be supplied with more and more resources to combat. Illich points to iatrogenic (doctor-caused) medical conditions like complications from surgery and side effects from pharmaceutical drugs as examples of this phenomenon in medicine (Illich 1973 & 1975). At this point, it may well be that the continued growth of the institution creates new problems at a faster rate than it solves them, eventually reversing the first watershed and becoming more of a hindrance than a help to human conviviality¹. Nevertheless, the rolling inertia produced by industrialization keeps these overgrown institutions going even when their continued existence, or at least their current condition, is unhelpful or dangerous.

Outside of medical sociology, Illich (1973) has often been overlooked and under-cited in science and technology studies. Without explicitly referring to Illich or using his language, however, the economic sociology literature regarding algorithmic governance and the development of FICO-assisted credit rating in particular is unambiguous that this institution has crossed its second watershed. Credit markets have brought with them ever-increasing economic growth, but this growth has been associated with similarly increasing pervasion of the institution of credit into social life that has borne considerable costs for the vast majority of Americans who are obligated to take part in it (Quinn 2019). Carruthers (2022) argues that credit cards have served as a form of social control (a manipulative rather than a convivial tool, in Illich's language) since as early as the antebellum South. He describes how bank-supplied credit and other, more nakedly predatory forms of "other people's money" such as payday loans work together to keep the "economy of promises" afloat, providing much-needed liquidity to market participants who would not otherwise have access to it but putting them on the hook for (literally) exponentially increasing debt in the process. As algorithms, most pre-eminently FICO scoring, have become the dominant technological tools of the institution of credit, Carruthers discusses how they have become totalizing and hegemonic elements of social life interlinked with the surveillance state and other vectors of social control. Quinn (2019) investigates at length the integration of political institutions into credit markets, as well as how credit technology has

¹ "Conviviality" is a very loaded term in *Tools for Conviviality* (1973), and Illich spends much of the text expanding upon what he means by it and what it might look like in practice. The long and short of it is that a convivial society has overcome the relentless overproduction induced by industrialization and capitalism and built a more sustainable system of tools that permits its people to enjoy as much liberty as possible without transgressing on that of others.

slowly come to define how Americans determine what they owe each other in everyday life. The changes to credit have seeped osmotically into many other walks of life.

Lauer (2017) describes how the technological and normative changes to the institution of credit since the early twentieth century have reshaped the idealized concept of creditworthiness in the American cultural consciousness. In the nineteenth century, Lauer argues, creditworthiness was a personal, qualitative aspect of character (and as we will see in the preliminary analysis, this idea has not fully faded away). But as credit bureaus and banks sought to reduce the risk of their representatives misjudging the character of prospective debtors — or perhaps the inefficiency introduced by regarding character as an imperfect proxy for risk of non-repayment — they introduced and standardized changes like credit cards, FICO scores, stratified accounts, small loans, and pre-approval that slowly altered this perception (Anderson 2008, Carruthers et al. 2012). This combated allegations of interpersonal racial discrimination against Black prospective borrowers by loan officers and bank reps (Marron 2008) and otherwise increased consumer trust (Guseva and Rona-Tas 2001), but at the same time it assigned an esoteric quality to credit ratings because they are determined by an inherently uninterpretable “black box” (Rudin 2019). The creditworthy American of the twenty-first century is still commonly regarded as a competent and capable financial citizen, but due to their ability to follow the algorithmic rules rather than their general trustworthiness in interpersonal dealings. Their face has been contorted from that of an honest member of society into that of a financial self who knows how to game the system and trusts the institutions to reward them for doing so with low interest rates and good equity.

This standardizing transformation of the institution of credit and the idealized role of the prospective borrower has come with a corresponding change to the function of credit scores as institutional tools. Poon (2012) argues that the usefulness of credit ratings as practical assessments of non-repayment risk has deteriorated. According to Poon, FICO scores no longer operate as rational evaluations but as rationalized mechanisms that determine the opportunity structures market participants must navigate, rewarding them for certain behavior and punishing them for alternative behavior rather than accurately determining whether they are likely to pay back loans. With the exceptions of the extremely wealthy and the bankrupt, Americans cannot avoid participating in credit scoring without declining to participate in financial life in general. It is virtually impossible to buy or rent a place to live, open a bank account, or even pay for things in an increasingly cashless society without receiving a FICO score or being underwritten or guaranteed by someone who has a good one (Lauer 2017, Quinn 2019, Carruthers 2022). This means that declining to play by the rules is not a reasonable option for the vast majority of Americans if they do not want to pay an enormous cost in liquidity, convenience, and financial freedom, and those who fail to play by the rules will face financial hurdles that sometimes take decades of belabored tactics to overcome, regardless of whether they are actually likely to pay loans back. Since FICO algorithms are predictive rather than explanatory, individuals are judged morally based on financial actions with no consensus moral valence (Fourcade and Healy 2017).

Meanwhile, scholars like Fourcade and Healy (2013 & 2017) and Kiviat (2023 & 2026) interrogate how algorithmic systems of governance repeatedly force individuals into scenarios that stratify them by class. Despite their portrayal as unbiased and trustworthy assessors of creditworthiness (Guseva and Rona-Tas 2001, Marron 2008), the widespread adoption of credit technology as a powerful driver of economic growth has interacted with and in many cases reinforced pre-existing social boundaries along racial, class, and gender lines (Quinn 2019). Infamously, it took until 1974 for American women to be able to take out a credit card in their own name, and there is compounding and compelling evidence that facially race-neutral credit algorithms may nevertheless enforce racially stratified outcomes, partially because the subjective experience of being scored by an algorithm differs along racial lines (Norris 2025). Complex, proprietary “black box” models like the FICO algorithm are inherently opaque and may reproduce bias or group-level stratification without the intention or knowledge of their creators (Rudin 2019). Most significantly for the algorithmic governance literature, “classification situations,” life chances where individuals are sorted by these algorithms into categories like “presumed creditworthy” or “presumed uncreditworthy” or along scales of creditworthiness, almost invariably appear to reproduce stratification by class (Fourcade and Healy 2013). The logic of algorithmic classification has serious ontological consequences, construing engaged and embedded actors as cut-and-dry “cases” based on assessments by algorithms nobody can reproduce and which do not even seem to work properly for the credit bureaus (Kiviat 2023). Prospective seekers of credit might hope to be considered exceptional cases and receive some kind of special dispensation from the bank, yet cases they remain. At least in the case of tenant screening, they can only hope to be given this exceptional treatment if their circumstances are pre-specified within the rules; that is, institutionally legible (Kiviat et al. 2026).

But notice what has happened here. As the algorithmic tools of credit, in particular FICO scores, have become rationalized as trustworthy arbiters of classification (Guseva and Rona-Tas 2001), one of the dramaturgical roles in the credit-seeking encounter has been re-cast, and it is not that of the prospective debtor. Before the standardization of FICO scores in 1989, borrowers knew that their financial behavior would be analyzed by loan officers or bank representatives to determine whether to extend them credit and at how favorable of a rate (Carruthers 2022). After FICO scores became mandatory in 1995, consumers continued to perform the “creditworthy” role through specific financial behaviors, even though a situational performance of trust has been replaced by a more abstract system of classification situations. The range of tactics they can adopt to succeed in the market has been reduced, but they still adopt tactics to succeed in the market. On the other hand, the representative of the bank has quietly ceded their role to the FICO algorithm. Their job is no longer to make the determination of whether a client is creditworthy, but to communicate and justify the determination made by the machine. I argue that this is beneficial to the bank even if algorithmic credit scores are insufficient or even inefficient replacements for human assessments of trust (Poon 2012) because it gives them plausible deniability. It transfers the responsibility for deciding who gets money and who has to stay poor

from a human being whose biases and inefficiencies are legible to market participants (Marron 2008) to an uninterpretable algorithm whose shortcomings are inscrutable and proprietary.

One of the more important social roles among the ancient Etruscans, later adopted by their Roman successors, was that of the *haruspex*. This specialized priest would augur the future and determine the right course of action to navigate that future through the practice of hepatoscopy, the inspection of the liver (as well as other entrails) of an animal sacrifice (Tuck 2020, Rosmalen et al. 2022). The Etruscans believed that the characteristics of these organs, examined carefully by a professional, could accurately reveal the will and desires of the gods. Scholars argue that this rationalized practice persisted well into the Roman period and even beyond because it justified the ideological hegemony of the senatorial class (Ripat 2006). I contend that the new role of the bank representative in the credit-seeking encounter is that of a (post)modern *haruspex*. They interpret a three-digit number, FICO score, output by an algorithm most people trust (Guseva and Rona-Tas 2001) but almost nobody — indeed, perhaps nobody at all — can understand (Rudin 2019). Their role is to explain and justify this output, an intermediary between the algorithm and the consumer rather than an interactor with authority to make a judgment of creditworthiness. The authority now belongs to the tool rather than the user.

The role of the *haruspex* appears associated with institutions that cross their second threshold. Given that the costs and harms of algorithmic credit (totalizing financial behavior, surveillance, reinforcing stratification) may well have exceeded the benefits (universal standards, ostensible neutrality), it is in the interests of financial institutions to justify to consumers why they must participate in it. Like Roman divination (Ripat 2006), algorithmic credit provides an unfalsifiable justification for class stratification. As individuals participate in classification situations, they may come to doubt the validity of the premise that FICO scores accurately separate the creditworthy from the uncreditworthy, especially if they find themselves adjudicated into the latter category (Poon 2012, Fourcade and Healy 2013). When this happens, it is the job of the *haruspex*, the new role of the representative of the bank, to justify the judgment and in so doing rationalize the institution to the potentially disgruntled client. When the score is too low, they become an advisor, guiding the prospective debtor to the right course of action to earn the right to borrow money they will later have to pay back at interest. When the score is high enough, they become a salesperson, offering whatever terms the algorithm predicts will be most profitable for both parties (or at least the bank). A deeper look at the transformation of the idealized role of the bank rep may help illuminate how the *haruspical* role emerges as an institution crosses its second watershed.

As I proceed with my (in progress) analysis, I am going to examine whether the *FDIC Consumer News* and popular press consumer advice literature, treated as Goffmanian scripts for action that explain how to cultivate face for prospective borrowers, supports my assertions about the *haruspical* transformation of the idealized representative of the credit-lending institution. As the institution of credit crossed its second watershed, it likely produced evidence of a discursive shift about bank reps and loan officers.

Content and Methods

I first identify a few canonical consumer advice texts for personal finance and credit to anchor the analysis in what the financially informed public was and is broadly reading. For pre-FICO documents, I select Sylvia Porter's legendary *Money Book* (the 1976 edition) and Andrew Tobias's *The Only Investment Guide You'll Ever Need* (the 1978 edition). Porter's *Money Book*, according to Lucht (2013), essentially "created [the] genre" of personal finance and credit management books, proving particularly important for women as they experienced newfound access to credit in the 1970s. Tobias's *Investment Guide* has not quite risen to the same status, but has proven an enduring bestseller through many reprints and updates and is valuable particularly because it has been revised for the post-FICO world. For post-FICO documents, I use the 2022 edition of Tobias's *Investment Guide*, as well as Liz Weston's *Your Credit Score, Your Money and What's at Stake: How to Improve the 3-Digit Number that Shapes Your Financial Future* (the 2009 edition). With Tobias, I can observe how a single author's advice to a likely similar target audience of consumers has changed since the imposition of algorithmic credit via FICO. With Weston, I have a consistently bestselling piece of consumer advice literature that deals almost exclusively with credit score.

I use the *FDIC Consumer News*, recorded online in the publicly available FDIC archive at archive.fdic.gov, as a stable spine for my corpus due to its history of print dating back to the pre-FICO 1980s and its frequent articles advising consumers about their credit score. These documents were published irregularly on a monthly basis by the FDIC during 1981 and 1982, then again on a quarterly basis beginning in fall 1993 until summer 2018. From August 2018 to the present, the *Consumer News* has returned to a monthly schedule. I break this publication history down into four temporal categories: pre-FICO (the 11 publications from 1981 and 1982), mid-FICO (the 9 publications from 1993, 1994, and 1995, between the first scoring algorithm and the mandatory standardization of FICO for underwriting mortgages), early FICO (the 40 publications from 1996 to 2005, the first ten years after FICO became mandatory), and post-FICO (all publications since 2006). Many of these publications do not mention credit score at all (for example, literature warning consumers against common financial scams), so I will discard them for the purposes of this paper. There is still a high concentration of articles about credit, credit reports, and credit scoring across the four time periods and I should be able to reach thematic saturation as I proceed with my analysis, even if not all of these articles explicitly mention prospective lenders, bank representatives, or loan officers.

I approach the content using an iterative categorization process adapted from Neale (2016). To establish themes, I conduct a first pass of the popular press literature and the more substantive credit-related articles in the *FDIC Consumer News* from each of my four time periods. This is the current stage of my analysis, and I eagerly welcome recommendations as I proceed with my iterative coding, as well as suggestions for additional data sources. Once I have established key themes within the popular press books and the *Consumer News*, as well as cutting across them, I will proceed by coding the books in their entirety, all of the relevant

pre-FICO and mid-FICO *Consumer News* articles due to the comparatively small sample size, and the early FICO and post-FICO *Consumer News* articles until I reach saturation.

Preliminary Findings

My analysis itself is still in its early stages, and the limited findings I present here are subject to change.

My initial findings follow a few clear patterns. First, the popular press consumer advice literature clearly displays loan officers and bank representatives in a central role as adjudicators of creditworthiness before FICO, whereas it portrays them as accessories to credit scoring algorithms afterwards, or at best as advisors for borrowers. For example, in Porter's *Money Book* (1976), it is the "lenders" themselves who "decide, on the basis of information provided by the credit bureau, whether or not you are a good credit risk." There are a few points, i.e. tactics (Certeau 1980), which "every lending officer will tick off when considering your application for a loan." Should the reader be embroiled in litigation, repossession, or other financial trouble with a loan, Porter recommends they "go to your credit granters first, explain what happened, and in many cases they will be willing to extend your payment schedule." Three decades later, Weston (2009) describes a very different situation. "In the days before the widespread use of a credit score," she writes, "a broker or loan officer could intervene to convince a lender to ignore mistakes or small blemishes on a client's credit file." But "with the advent of credit scoring and automated loan processes, though, those opportunities to advocate for clients quickly evaporated." Weston's post-FICO loan officers are sidelined, deprived of the ability to adjudicate for themselves whether a client is creditworthy. Instead, they occupy an intermediary, haruspical position. Consider one of Weston's "credit-scoring myths:" that a written statement to the credit bureaus can help repair your credit. Unlike Porter's potentially generous credit granters, Weston says that today's bureaus have no way of taking statements from borrowers advocating for themselves into account. "It's not clear how helpful such statements were before credit scoring became so widespread, but they're certainly not much help now." Weston recommends that credit card users trying to handle a faulty charge follow the "dispute-resolution process as outlined on the back of your statements." The representatives of the company, who "once upon a time" would have had the authority to resolve the credit problem themselves, were by 2009 only capable of intermediating between the disgruntled borrower and the scoring algorithm. After 1995, Weston writes, "it was in the course of conversations [about mortgages] that an increasing number of consumers started hearing about FICOs and credit scores. For the first time, people learned that the reason they did or didn't get the loan they wanted was because of a three-digit number." The responsibility for the decision was now literally out of the hands of prospective lenders. It now fell to the scoring algorithm to determine who got what they wanted.

Second, the *FDIC Consumer News* spends a lot of time in the pre-FICO period discussing the potential human biases of loan officers and bank representatives as a common concern, but they appear less and less throughout its pages with and after the introduction of FICO. Every single article of the *Consumer News* that mentions credit from the pre-FICO period (January,

February, March, April, May, June, July, and October 1981 and January and May 1982) also mentions consumer protection laws like the Equal Credit Opportunity Act, Fair Credit Reporting Act, and Truth in Lending Act that limited what the representatives of creditors were legally allowed to ask prospective debtors (to prevent discrimination, opaque business practices, and so on). Across the early FICO and post-FICO periods, these concerns vanish. After FICO, the prospective borrower as idealized by the FDIC is much more concerned with managing their file than managing the individual impression of them held by whoever happens to be reading their file or meeting with them to discuss a new line of credit. Hopeful borrowers are instructed to “regularly review your credit reports” (Summer 2007), and understand that “your credit history determines your [credit] score, and the higher your score, the better loan terms become” (June 2019). But beware: “a poor credit score may mean you can only qualify for a “subprime” loan” (Winter 2002/2003). This transition from impression management *a la* Goffman (1959) to score management suggests that the meaningful interlocutor with the prospective borrower in the idealized post-FICO credit-seeking encounter is no longer the representative of the disbursing of credit; it is the credit-scoring algorithm itself.

When preparing to save up for a house, consumers are encouraged to “check with your bank about linking a savings account to your checking account” to add to their savings and improve their credit scores (June 2019). The representative of the bank in this scripted scenario is in charge of setting up a pathway by which the prospective borrower can appeal to the algorithm, not adjudicating whether to extend them credit. In a pattern that cuts across the popular press literature and the *Consumer News*, mortgage brokers specifically retain some power of judgment: both Weston (2009) and the June 2019 issue of the *Consumer News* describe the mortgage-seeking process as significantly more involved and less automated than everyday credit-seeking behavior in the post-FICO world. In these scenarios, prospective borrowers experience something much more similar to the classic assessments of Porter’s *Money Book* (1976) than the algorithmic classification situations of Fourcade and Healy (2013 & 2017), with mortgage brokers taking the responsibility of looking through documents and making judgments themselves, underwritten but not dominated by credit score alone. Perhaps, with a high-value prospect like a mortgage on the line, prospective creditors are subtly indicating that, like many consumers, they don’t fully trust the output of the algorithm to make the decision for them.

Third, across both the popular press literature and the *Consumer News*, credit scores are presented textually as tools used by lenders to make decisions rather than as direct arbiters of who gets a loan. However, they are manipulative tools (Illich 1973) that shape the field of consumer credit and promote unrestricted industrial growth without much room for situational discretion by their users. Weston (2009) tells her audience:

“Credit scoring is one of the reasons why consumer credit absolutely exploded in the 1990s. Lenders felt more confident about making loans to wider groups of people because they had a more precise tool for measuring risk. Credit scoring

also allowed them to make decisions faster, enabling them to make more loans. The result was an unprecedented rise in the amount of available consumer credit.”

In Porter’s *Money Book* (1976), loan officers use many tools to make determinations about who gets credit: bureau-compiled credit reports, longer investigative reports, personal meetings, bespoke scoring systems, and so on. But across the pages of the post-FICO *Consumer News*, prospective lenders increasingly defer to FICO scores or other nationalized algorithms to make the determinations. As of the Winter 2002/2003 issue, credit scores work alongside credit reports and other information to “help banks, insurers, landlords, and even potential employers make judgments about your reliability.” By Summer 2005, lenders may “require a score of 680 or higher,” so if “the scoring system the lender is using puts you at 660, tak[e] steps to improve your score.” By Summer 2007, “a credit score is a number that is based on your credit report and reflects your financial responsibility.” This transition from the credit score working alongside other tools to help a lender make a decision about reliability to the credit score representing reliability is subtle, but impossible to ignore in the data. The role of the score has replaced that of the loan officer: it now “can determine your chances for a low-interest loan or a lower interest rate on a credit card” (Summer 2007). The tool itself now makes the determination rather than the prospective creditor making the determination by using the tool. The discursive change of the representative of credit from a savvy financial professional to a haruspex, an accessory, or even a vestigial element of the credit-seeking encounter is well underway.

Preliminary Discussion

Guseva and Rona-Tas (2001) compare the robust American credit market to its Russian counterpart, and find that whereas American creditors overwhelmingly assess risk using algorithms like FICO scores, Russian creditors lack access to this technology and defer to trust, relying on existing and new social ties to help them determine to whom to lend. My theoretical discussion and preliminary findings suggest that this distinction between haruspical American creditors and deliberative Russian creditors is not coincidental. In Russia, the institution of credit was new in 2001 and the credit market “was conceived with none of its logical precursors present” (Guseva and Rona-Tas 2001). In that sense, it was a rational institution that had crossed its first watershed, but not yet a rationalized institution that had crossed its second (Illich 1973). The nascent Russian credit market emerged to supplant pre-existing and mostly informal credit systems from the Soviet period, mirroring the early American credit market by providing the inhabitants of a rapidly democratizing economy with much-needed liquidity and a coherent network of debt. As of 2001, it had not yet begun to persist on its own as a rationalized institution, and it had not introduced the kind of problems the American credit market requires non-falsifiable, haruspical justifications to explain.

A considerable limitation of my empirical research design is that, because of the nature of my content analysis, I can really only make claims about scripts for the credit-seeking encounter rather than the credit-seeking encounter as it actually exists. Accordingly, I cannot argue that

bank representatives *actually* function as haruspices in the post-FICO world. What I can and do argue is that credit-seekers have been primed by the contemporary consumer advice literature, including directly from the FDIC, to act as though their interlocutors when seeking credit are scoring algorithms and file systems rather than individual institutional representatives with discriminatory authority over their life chances like they were before FICO. They are being encouraged to treat the credit-seeking encounter precisely as a classification situation that determines their life chances (Fourcade and Healy 2013), and they are being encouraged to treat their whole financial lives as series of credit-seeking encounters (Quinn 2019). Data availability for other kinds of sociological analysis besides content analysis regarding pre-FICO credit-seeking is poor, and even the available pre-FICO archival content and consumer advice literature is sparse compared to the post-FICO content, so an analysis of discourse to see how the interactions that populate this institution have changed in America is the best option.

That being said, there are numerous potential empirical venues to observe how credit functions across societies that have not yet adopted algorithmic credit, or where its adoption is limited or underway. Guseva and Rona-Tas (2001) provide an excellent example of this with their comparative case studies of the United States and Russia, and there are many countries and economies across Europe, Africa, Asia, Oceania, and Latin America where this technology and its associated institution are not yet totalizing or rationalized. I strongly encourage further empirical research into these sites, particularly through participant observation of the credit-seeking interaction itself both in the United States and in other cases where credit is less algorithmic. This proposed research could help connect the arguments I make in this paper about discourse to actual interactions in everyday life and observe how the representatives of credit, and not just their idealized roles as imagined in the consumer advice literature, differ from site to site. It might also help establish a better understanding of how the role of the credit haruspex is actually played, and not just written.

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